



A Question About H2

Is the triad the right unit for this hypothesis?

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For Prof. William Newbury · 19 September 2026

THE SHORT VERSION

My hypothesis says a commercial research panel should be home-region bound. I have been measuring region on the triad.

Fainshmidt and colleagues suggest the triad may be the wrong unit, and they have already built the alternative.

This is a question, not a conclusion. Nobody has tested either version.



ALL FIVE READINGS

Each one denies that the backdrop holds still

Most international business research treats institutions and culture as a stable setting against which firms act. These five deny that in five different ways.

Fainshmidt et al. (2018)

There are seven kinds of institutional system, not two

Cuervo-Cazurra et al. (2019)

Institutions swing back and forth. Reform reverses

House et al. (2002)

Culture is nine-dimensional, and mostly universal anyway

Deephouse, Newburry & Soleimani (2016)

The same firm earns a different reputation depending where it sits

Samiee et al. (2024)

After sixty years the field still cannot agree what origin does

The session is not really about institutions. It is about what happens to a comparative claim when the thing you were holding constant turns out to vary.



THE ONE I READ FIRST

Deephouse, Newburry & Soleimani (2016)

401 corporations across 25 countries, reputation measured in 2007, 2009 and 2011, with independent variables lagged so respondents could plausibly have known them.

THE RESULT THAT IS WORTH THE PAPER

Reputation is **NEGATIVELY** related to institutional development, at $p < 0.001$. In less developed economies corporations fill institutional voids and expectations of them are lower.

THE SENTENCE I WILL BORROW

In a cross-national study the relevant comparison group is not the same in every country. That is the cleanest statement I have found of why one average conceals more than it reports.

It is the same claim I make about overall response rates in comparative survey work: the mean across frames is nearly uninformative, and the minimum is decisive. Their version is better evidenced than mine.



THE ONE THAT CHANGED THE DESIGN

Fainshmidt, Judge, Aguilera & Smith (2018)

Institutional profiles of 68 economies across 13 elements, built from expert judgement and sorted by two-step cluster analysis. Aimed deliberately at the economies Varieties of Capitalism and National Business Systems leave out.

FIVE DIMENSIONS

- The state
- Financial markets
- Human capital
- Social capital
- Corporate governance

AND THE STATE ITSELF IS TYPED

SEVEN TYPES

- State-Led
- Fragmented with a Fragile State
- Family-Led
- Centralized Tribe
- Emergent LME
- Collaborative Agglomerations
- Hierarchically Coordinated

Predatory, developmental, welfare or regulatory, measured separately from direct dominance and indirect intervention. Fainshmidt is at FIU.



WHERE MY PROJECT STANDS

H2, as I wrote it for the 18 September deck

H2. The observable prevalence of a narrow specialist professional population on a commercial research panel is higher within the panel provider's home region than outside it.

The logic is Rugman and Verbeke's own. Of the 380 largest multinationals with usable sales data, 320 were home-region oriented at 80.3 percent of sales, and only nine were global. Their mechanism is that upstream advantages in technology travel while downstream advantages such as branding are location-bound.

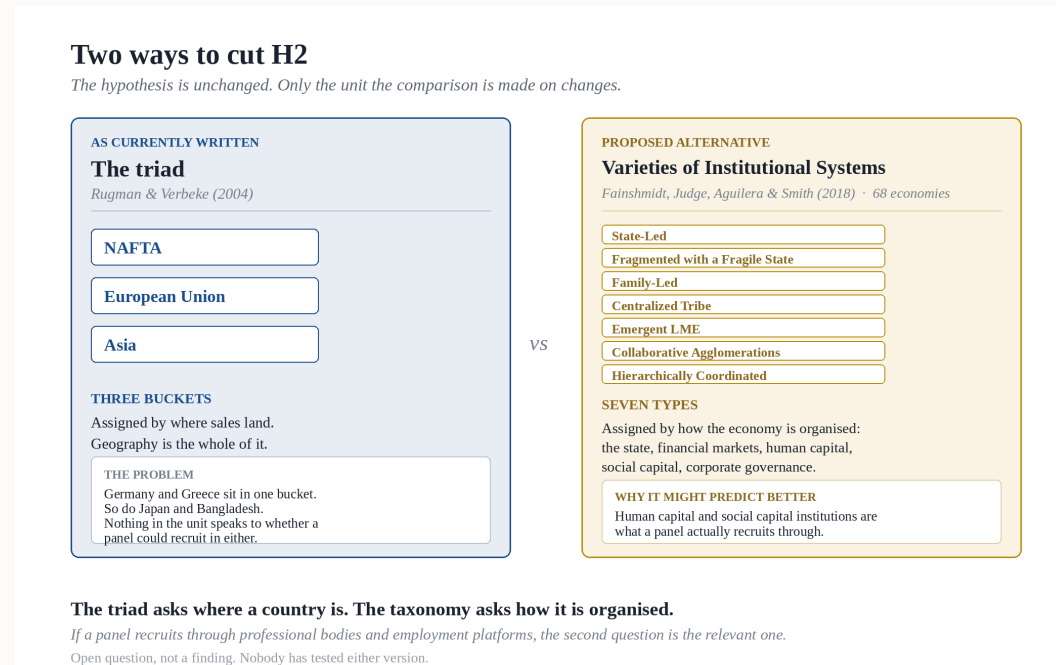
A research panel is a firm whose entire product is a downstream asset: its membership, and its standing with that membership. Survey software is a commodity, so there is almost no upstream advantage to carry abroad. On their own account a panel should be MORE home-region bound than a manufacturer, not less.

That argument I am confident in. What I am no longer confident in is the unit I chose to test it on.



THE QUESTION

Is the triad the right unit for this hypothesis?



If what actually determines whether a panel can reach a specialist professional population is the configuration of human capital institutions, social capital and the character of the state, then two countries inside one triad region can differ more than two countries across regions.



IF THE ANSWER IS YES

What testing it would actually require

1

Nothing new to collect

Both classifications are published. Rugman and Verbeke assign the triad; Fainshmidt and colleagues assign 68 economies to seven types.

2

The panel providers still have to vary

H2 is unidentifiable if every provider originates in one place. That constraint is unchanged.

3

It becomes a competing-specifications test

Run the model both ways and report which classification explains more. That is a stronger paper than assuming one.

4

The risk is coverage

Fainshmidt covers 68 economies and the triad covers everything. If my frames fall outside the 68, the comparison narrows.



WHAT I AM ASKING

Is this worth doing, or am I complicating a hypothesis that works?

I can defend the argument behind H2. I am less sure the triad is the unit that tests it, and I would rather hear that now than in the October report.

The taxonomy already exists, it was built for exactly the economies a commercial panel is least likely to cover, and one of its authors is at FIU.

THE HONEST POSITION

This is a question about a design, not a finding. No data has been collected for the project, and neither version of H2 has been tested by anyone.

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